

Blàths

warmth · blossom

/blas/ · “blaas”

Skye Community Sauna

Site shortlist: six candidate sites assessed for footfall, site control and cold plunge access.

Companion to the Project Overview.

Read alongside the main Blàths project overview document



01 Context

Two-site launch planned. Primary criteria: footfall, site control (who grants permission) and water access for cold plunge. The sailing club Portree site is now under application by a competitor; this document covers the revised shortlist.

Tier 1, Harbour & Pier Sites: anchor candidates with plunge water, real infrastructure and manageable permissions.

Tier 2, Honeypot-Adjacent Sites: no plunge water, but exceptional footfall and views. Higher approval complexity; better as later-phase or pop-up plays.

02 Uig Ferry Terminal

Footfall type	Ferry passengers (Outer Hebrides triangle), year-round
Cold plunge	Yes. Sheltered Uig Bay, tidal sea loch
Water access	Strong; exposed bay but well flushed
Trailer access	Excellent. Newly rebuilt HGV-grade port, large hardstanding
Mains power	Yes, utility provision installed as part of the 2023/24 terminal redevelopment

Who We Need Approval From

Highland Council (harbour authority, owns the port) is the primary gatekeeper. The key opportunity is CMAL's surplus old terminal site: CMAL has confirmed it plans to demolish the old terminal building and market the site, with evaluation criteria that explicitly weight community benefit alongside commercial value. A community-priced sauna is a near-perfect fit for this test.

Contact: uigsite@cmassets.co.uk

Foreshore licence via Crown Estate Scotland / Bidwells is only triggered if anything is sited below the mean high-water mark. Keeping the unit on the existing hardstanding avoids this entirely.

Approval Steps

- 01** Express interest in the CMAL surplus site, leading with the community benefit case
- 02** Highland Council harbourmaster discussion in parallel
- 03** Highland Council planning pre-application enquiry (temporary vs. permanent siting)

- 04 SEPA self-assessment for plunge water quality
- 05 Crown Estate foreshore consent only if siting extends below the high-water line

Strategic Notes

Ferry dwell-time at Uig is approximately 30 to 45 minutes, almost exactly a sauna session. Captured audience, no competing activity, predictable throughput. The redeveloped terminal means real toilets, power and covered waiting already exist. Weaknesses: a busy working port with vehicle movements; open Minch exposure means swell on wind days; less charm than a fishing pier.

03 Broadford Pier

Footfall type	A87 gateway traffic, year-round local community, second-largest settlement
Cold plunge	Yes. Broadford Bay, Inner Sound
Water access	Good; sheltered bay, check tidal flushing at head of bay
Trailer access	Excellent. Right on the A87, two piers accessible by road
Mains power	Yes, full village services including hospital, supermarket, filling station

Two Pier Options

New Pier / Corry (western side of bay): working fishing pier and yacht moorings, parking nearby, built 1904 by the Skye Marble Company. More of a working-harbour feel. Old Pier (village centre, behind the former Dunollie Hotel): 1807 dressed dry-stone, L-shaped, surrounded by small shops. More character and better visual appeal.

Who We Need Approval From

Highland Council is harbour authority. The community angle is strong here: Broadford & Strath Community Company is an active local body (recently in receipt of Highland Coastal Communities funding) and a natural partner for social licence and grant co-application.

Contact: Kyle Harbour Master, 01599 534589

Crown Estate foreshore consent only applies if siting goes below the high-water line.

Approval Steps

- 01 Kyle Harbour Master, initial scoping call
- 02 Broadford & Strath Community Company, partnership conversation
- 03 Highland Council planning pre-application enquiry

- 04 SEPA water quality self-assessment (Broadford Bay)
- 05 Community Regeneration Fund grant alignment

Strategic Notes

Best overall fit for the community-first brand: Highland Council harbour, an active community company to partner with, year-round reliable trade, and every grant lever (community pricing, placemaking, responsible tourism, overtourism response) lines up cleanly. The Skye Marble Company heritage on the New Pier is a useful brand hook. Footfall is steady passing and residential trade rather than honeypot spikes, a virtue for shoulder-season viability. One Broadford-area operator already exists (Suilanu, women-only retreats on a private croft), but it is a different product on private land and not a competitive blocker.

04 Dunvegan Pier

Footfall type	Dunvegan Castle visitors (115,000+/yr), seal-trip passengers, Loch Dunvegan area (370,000 visits/yr)
Cold plunge	Yes. Loch Dunvegan, sheltered sea loch
Water access	Good; sheltered in any wind, deep, excellent for plunge
Trailer access	Good. A863/A850 approach, parking above the slip; road narrows approaching the village
Mains power	Village services a short walk away; a connection is needed rather than plug-in-ready

Who We Need Approval From

Unlike the other two, this is entirely a private landowner conversation. The pier is owned and managed by the MacLeod Estate.

Contact: Pier Master, MacLeod Estate, Dunvegan House, IV55 8WF. 01470 521206.
pier@dunvegancastle.com

This is a single point of entry, which is simple, but the Estate is commercially minded (it runs the moorings and the castle's own boat trips) and will expect ground rent or a revenue share. Unlike the Highland Council harbours, there is no community trust or public-interest angle to leverage; it is a straight commercial negotiation.

The pier is in active daily use by fishing boats, which discard catch over the side. Plunge entry should be positioned away from the working berths, likely towards the castle jetty end.

Approval Steps

- 01 MacLeod Estate, Pier Master initial approach
- 02 Negotiate licence terms (ground rent or revenue share)
- 03 Highland Council planning pre-application (development on private land)
- 04 Crown Estate consent if any foreshore structure sits below the high-water line
- 05 SEPA water quality self-assessment (position away from fish waste)

Strategic Notes

Highest raw footfall of the three, and Loch Dunvegan is the best plunge water: very sheltered, with strong tidal renewal. Main risks: Estate leverage (if the sauna performs well, the Estate could simply not renew the licence, or build its own), winter seasonality (the castle closes and the village quieters sharply), and fishing pier aesthetics at the working berths. Best positioned as a high-footfall second site rather than a community-first anchor.

05 Old Man of Storr (vicinity)

Tier 2 site. No cold plunge water. The product here is sauna with a view, a legitimate but largely unoccupied market position, approached as a later-phase or pop-up play rather than a launch anchor.

Footfall	150,000 to 200,000 visitors/year; one of Skye's busiest walks
Cold plunge	No. Storr Lochs is a hydro reservoir; no practical sea or river access at the car park
Trailer access	Yes. 140-space car park on the A855, hardstanding, toilets on site
Mains power	No on-site supply; generator or solar required

Who Controls It

Highland Council owns the car park land. However, Staffin Community Trust has lodged a formal Asset Transfer Request to take over the Council land to build parking, toilets and visitor interpretation, backed by strong community empowerment legislation. The practical gatekeeper may become the Trust rather than Highland Council, and the Trust is the same community network as Staffin Sea Sauna, our Trotternish competitor.

Designation Stack

National Scenic Area (Trotternish). Special Area of Conservation across the entire Trotternish escarpment, the highest protection tier. No open fires are permitted at the site under existing access guidance, a direct conflict with the wood-fired model.

Approval Steps

- 01 Establish whether the Asset Transfer Request has been granted and who actually controls the land
- 02 If Highland Council: planning in an NSA and SAC, requiring landscape and visual impact assessment plus NatureScot statutory consultation
- 03 Address the open-fire restriction; a smokeless or electric backup heat source may be required as a condition
- 04 SEPA water and waste consent
- 05 Generator or solar for mains-free operation

Strategic Notes

The open-fire restriction is a harder operational constraint than it first appears; it goes to the core product. The overlap with Staffin Community Trust territory is awkward given our existing relationship with the Staffin sauna community. A better approach: a site on private croft land within sight of the Storr, a short distance from the car park, avoids all of these complications while still capturing the

association.

06 Quiraing

Footfall	Very high; one of Skye's most photographed landscapes
Cold plunge	No water access at or near the car park
Trailer access	Challenging. Single-track road with passing places; no formal turning facility
Mains power	None

Who Controls It

Land ownership is likely a mix of private estate and crofting common grazings (Staffin or Uig township). Crofting common grazings add an extra approval layer: the common grazings committee and ultimately the Crofting Commission must consent to any commercial use.

Designation Stack

National Scenic Area, north Trotternish, the strongest NSA designation on the ridge. Special Area of Conservation. The Quiraing is also geologically the most active part of the Trotternish slip; the road at its base requires annual repairs due to ongoing ground movement, so anchoring any structure here carries structural risk.

Approval Steps

- 01 Establish land ownership via Registers of Scotland and NatureScot
- 02 Common grazings committee agreement, if grazing land
- 03 Crofting Commission consent
- 04 Highland Council planning in an NSA and SAC with NatureScot statutory consultation
- 05 Structural and geotechnical assessment given the active landslip
- 06 SEPA water and waste consent

Practical Pivot: Flodigarry Hotel

Flodigarry (Ed Wickman's other property) sits at the foot of the Quiraing on the eastern Trotternish coast. A sauna on Flodigarry's land would capture the Quiraing backdrop association with a fraction of the approval burden: private land with existing hospitality use, an established partner, no common grazings layer, and the same dramatic views without the active landslip risk. This is the recommended route to the Quiraing sauna experience.

07 Fairy Pools / Glenbrittle

Footfall	Extremely high; globally famous, among Skye's most-visited
Cold plunge	No. Pools are a 2.4km walk from the car park; no vehicle access
Trailer access	Car park is accessible but sits at the end of a long single-track road through Glenbrittle Forest
Mains power	None

Who Controls It

The land is part of the MacLeod Estate (Glenbrittle). The car park, however, is owned and operated by a separate community body (OATS sets and collects the parking fees). Both the Estate and the car-park community organisation need to be onside.

Designation Stack

Cuillin Hills National Scenic Area. SSSI across most of the Cuillin area. Special Protection Area for golden eagle habitat. Cuillin Wild Land Area, 183 square kilometres, the most heavily protected landscape category in Scotland; Scottish planning policy gives this specific protection against commercial development that compromises wild land character.

Approval Steps

- 01** MacLeod Estate agreement (the same estate as Dunvegan, so the relationship is already being built)
- 02** OATS / community car-park body agreement
- 03** Highland Council planning in an NSA, Wild Land Area and SSSI; a very high bar, with full environmental impact assessment likely required
- 04** NatureScot opinions on SSSI, SPA and Wild Land policy
- 05** SEPA water and waste consent

Practical Pivot: Glenbrittle Campsite

The MacLeod Estate runs the Glenbrittle Campsite & Cafe at the mouth of the glen, on Glenbrittle beach. This is a far better site: existing tourism use, the same landowner already being engaged for Dunvegan, direct beach access (cold plunge reinstated), full Cuillin views, and Fairy Pools overflow traffic. It converts a Tier 2 no-plunge concept back into a Tier 1 harbour or beach site with the same brand association. Strongly recommended as the Cuillin expression.

08 Summary Matrix

Site	Tier	Plunge	Footfall	Approval	Leverage risk	Role
Uig	1	Sea	High (ferry)	Medium	Low	Anchor candidate
Broadford	1	Sea	Med-high (yr-round)	Low-medium	Low	Anchor candidate
Dunvegan	1	Loch	Very high (seasonal)	Low	High	Second site
Storr vicinity	2	None	Very high	High	Medium	Pop-up / later
Quiraing / Flodigarry	2 to 1	No (Flodigarry)	Very high	High direct, low via Flodigarry	Low via Ed	Via Flodigarry
Fairy Pools / Glenbrittle	2 to 1	No (beach)	Extremely high	Very high, medium via campsite	Low via Estate	Via Glenbrittle Campsite

09 Recommended Launch Configuration

Site 1, Broadford Pier	Anchor	Community-first brand fit, year-round trade, Highland Council harbour, active community company partner, every grant lever lines up.
Site 2, Uig Ferry Terminal	Second site	CMAL community-benefit opening, captive ferry-dwell audience, the best infrastructure of any site, reliable footfall tied to sailings.
Site 3, Dunvegan Pier	Later phase	Highest seasonal footfall. Negotiate from a position of strength once the brand is established and the leverage dynamic with the Estate is more balanced.
Honeypot expression: Flodigarry or Glenbrittle Campsite	Future	Captures the iconic-view market via partner land, avoiding the designation stack entirely.

10 Key Contacts

CMAL Surplus Sites	Uig old terminal opportunity, uigsite@cmassets.co.uk
Kyle Harbour Master	Broadford pier authority, 01599 534589
MacLeod Estate Pier Master	Dunvegan pier, 01470 521206 · pier@dunvegancastle.com
Highland Council Planning	Pre-application enquiries, highland.gov.uk/planning
Crown Estate Scotland / Bidwells	Foreshore consent if needed, scotland-marine@bidwells.co.uk
NatureScot	SSSI / NSA / SAC consultation, naturescot.scot
SEPA	Water quality self-assessment, sepa.org.uk

This document covers site assessment as of June 2026. Approval contacts and designation status should be verified before submission. Read alongside the main Blàths project overview.